



An Army veteran told VA he was paralyzed. The government gave his family \$200,000 in disability payments.



PHOTOS OBTAINED BY THE WASHINGTON POST



Images obtained by The Post show he was faking it — like scores of other veterans.

VA disability runs on an ‘honor system.’ These veterans are defrauding it.

BY CRAIG WHITLOCK, LISA REIN AND NATE JONES

Kinsley Kilpatrick put on a convincing show.

During visits to Atlanta VA Medical Center, the Iraq War veteran arrived in a wheelchair, claiming multiple sclerosis had paralyzed his arms and legs. By the time he turned 35, the onetime athlete said he could barely move from the neck down, leaving him dependent on others to eat, dress and bathe, according to court records.

Obligated to help a former soldier in

need, the Department of Veterans Affairs began paying Kilpatrick \$7,900 a month in tax-free disability benefits in 2015, the records show. The federal government also gave him \$20,000 for a specially equipped Jeep Cherokee to make it easier for his wife to take him to medical appointments.

The hoax lasted for three years and might have continued indefinitely, if not for a whistleblower who sent VA proof that Kilpatrick was lying: videos

of the Army veteran backflipping on a trampoline, prancing around a sports field like a ballerina and swan diving into a playground ball pit.

VA’s \$193 billion disability program — one of the biggest line items in the federal budget — has become a rich target for fraudsters, according to a Washington Post investigation. Each year, the agency’s inspector general opens dozens of criminal cases into

SEE FRAUD ON A6

LEFT: Army veteran Kinsley Kilpatrick uses a wheelchair while attending a VA appointment. RIGHT: Kilpatrick posted a video online of himself jumping on a trampoline.

Thousands at FBI now working with ICE

BY PERRY STEIN

Nearly a quarter of the FBI’s roughly 13,000 agents across the country are currently assigned to immigration enforcement, with the number climbing to upward of 40 percent in the nation’s largest field offices, according to data from the FBI obtained by Sen. Mark R. Warner (D-Virginia) and shared with The Washington Post.

The large number of reassignments — about 3,000 agents — reflect a vast reshaping of the nation’s premier law enforcement agency, which has focused on national security threats since the Sept. 11, 2001, terrorist attacks. The intense focus on immigration has raised alarm among current and former FBI agents who say morale is low across the bureau as agents have less time to dedicate to the often complex cases they were hired to work on.

In the past, few FBI agents have been assigned to work on immigration enforcement alongside Immigration and Customs Enforcement, though the two agencies will

SEE IMMIGRATION ON A8

Trump urges jail in ICE dispute: Pritzker, Chicago mayor defiant. A3

Accused of lying, Comey pleads not guilty

BY SALVADOR RIZZO AND JEREMY ROEBUCK

Former FBI director James B. Comey pleaded not guilty Wednesday to charges that he lied to Congress in a case that has roiled the Justice Department and prompted alarm about its independence from the White House.

Defense attorney Patrick J. Fitzgerald entered the plea on Comey’s behalf during a brief arraignment before U.S. District Judge Michael S. Nachmanoff in Alexandria, Virginia. President Donald Trump demanded prosecutors pursue the case, despite long-standing concerns within the Justice Department that the

Trial set to start Jan. 5, but former FBI director’s lawyers to seek dismissal

evidence was insufficient.

The judge scheduled the trial to begin Jan. 5, but Fitzgerald said Comey’s defense team plans to file a series of motions by the end of the year seeking to dismiss the case on the grounds that it constitutes a vindictive prosecution; that the grand jury process used to indict Comey had been abused; that the government had exhibited outrageous conduct; and that

the interim U.S. attorney Trump installed with directions to charge Comey, Lindsey Halligan, was illegally appointed.

“It’s the honor of my life to represent Mr. Comey in this matter,” Fitzgerald said, adding, “This prosecution is brought at the direction of President Trump.”

Comey briefly addressed the judge, confirming that he understood his constitutional rights to remain silent and to be represented by counsel. His wife, Patrice Failor, and a daughter, Maurene Comey, a former federal prosecutor in Manhattan who was fired in July, were in the packed courtroom gallery for the arraignment,

SEE COMEY ON A5

Man charged with starting deadly Palisades Fire

BY JONATHAN EDWARDS, PRAVEENA SOMASUNDARAM, BRIANNA SACKS AND BEN BRASCH

A man was arrested Tuesday for allegedly starting the Palisades Fire, a blaze that raged for weeks, killing 12 people and destroying a huge swath of homes and buildings in a wealthy coastal neighborhood of Los Angeles.

Jonathan Rinderknecht, 29, of Melbourne, Florida, was charged with destruction of property by means of a fire, a felony that carries a five- to 20-year prison sentence, said Bill Essayli, the acting U.S. attorney for the Cen-

Small blaze set on Jan. 1 later grew into California disaster, officials say

tral District of California.

Investigators found a ChatGPT prompt by Rinderknecht asking the chatbot to make a “dystopian painting” that shows a crowd fleeing from a burning forest and poor people trying to get past a gate with a “big dollar sign on it,” wrote Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms and Explosives agent William Schry in a sworn

affidavit.

“On the other side of the gate and the entire wall is a conglomerate of the richest people,” the prompt allegedly read. “They are chilling, watching the world burn down, and watching the people struggle.”

The Palisades Fire, which flared up on Jan. 7, killed a dozen people, burned through more than 23,000 acres, and damaged or destroyed nearly 8,000 homes. It was the first and largest of a half-dozen firestorms that slammed the Los Angeles region, combining to kill 31 people, torch about 37,000 acres, and lead

SEE PALISADES ON A4

Gaza ceasefire is struck, a big step to end long war

ISRAEL AND HAMAS AGREE ON FIRST PHASE

Terms: Halt fighting, free hostages, allow aid influx

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM, HAZEM BALOUSHA, LIOR SOROKA AND MOHAMAD EL CHAMAA

Israel and Hamas agreed Wednesday to the first phase of a deal to end the two-year war in Gaza, President Donald Trump, Israeli and Hamas leaders said, moving closer to a halt to the most violent chapter in Israeli-Palestinian history since the establishment of the Israeli state. Trump’s announcement came hours after he told reporters he would soon visit the region to celebrate what he said was a historic occasion.

The ceasefire agreement and hostage deal aimed to bring immediate relief to the devastated,

starving population of Gaza in the form of a halt in fighting and a rush of humanitarian aid. Hamas agreed to release all the remaining hostages in exchange for Israel’s release of Palestinian prisoners, fulfilling a major Israeli demand to end the captivity.

The two sides appeared to have come to terms on Wednesday on just the initial phases of a deal, leaving long-term questions about Gaza’s fate unresolved. Previous ceasefires have fallen apart during the bitter arc of the conflict that began two years ago this week. But both sides expressed hope that they could continue efforts to stop the fighting for good, as Trump pushes a broader, 20-point plan

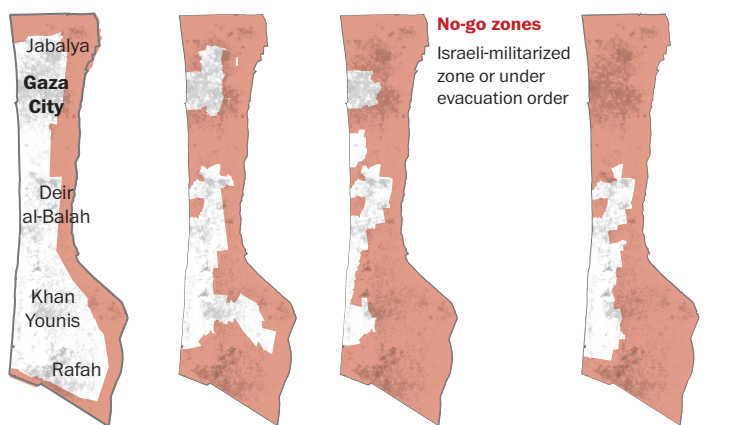
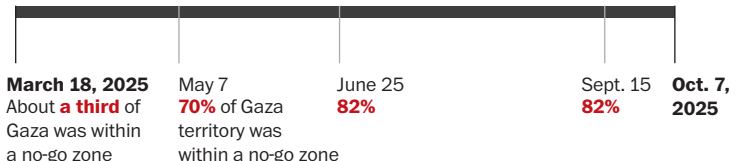
SEE CEASEFIRE ON A10

Two years since the Hamas attacks



SHRINKING GAZA

Since the end of the second ceasefire, the IDF pushed the population toward the south



Source: U.N. OCHA

Palestinian enclave shattered by ravages of a grueling war

Data shows the devastating impact that two years of conflict have had on lives, homes, heritage sites

BY VICTORIA BISSET, JÚLIA LEDUR AND ÁLVARO VALIÑO

It has been two years since Israel launched its war in Gaza in response to the deadly Hamas attacks of Oct. 7, 2023, which resulted in 251 hostages being taken into Gaza. Within days, the Israeli government declared a siege on Gaza, vowing “no electricity, no food, no fuel” would get through, and directed almost half of the population of 2 million to leave their homes in the north.

On Wednesday, just as the third year of the war was beginning, Israel and Hamas agreed to

the first phase of a deal to end the conflict, according to leaders for both sides and President Donald Trump.

The war has left much of Gaza in rubble and upended the lives of its inhabitants. Meanwhile, about 20 hostages are still believed to be alive in Gaza. Before October 2023, residents lived under a years-long Israeli blockade that restricted the movement of almost all people and goods in and out of the Strip. Leading human rights experts described the tiny territory as “the world’s largest open-air prison.”

But the enclave was also home

SEE GAZA ON A11

IN THE NEWS

Mass firings The president has often made the shutdown threat but hasn’t yet acted, fueling a rising belief that he’s bluffing. A4

Big races in jeopardy Organizers of the Army Ten-Miler and the Marine Corps Marathon said the government shutdown could affect their ability to proceed with race day. B13

THE NATION The Nobel Prize in chemistry went to three researchers for molecular breakthroughs. A2
Democrats are slow-walking their 2024 autopsy until past the November elections. A3

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THE ECONOMY Americans have become more pessimistic about AI. Four theories can help explain what’s behind the souring public opinion. A12
Layoffs are traumatic. Platitudes or jokes will only add to the hurt of joblessness, Michelle Singletary writes. A13

STYLE Timothée Chalamet’s “Marty Supreme” electrifies at the New York Film Festival in a surprise screening. B1

SPORTS The Nationals began a sweeping organizational overhaul with three longtime front-office executives departing. B7

THE REGION Democrats in Virginia are largely standing behind attorney general nominee Jay Jones after his violent texts. B13

LOCAL LIVING A woman’s struggle with deed fraud after the death of her father underscores the importance of estate planning.

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